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TAB 19



Board of Education Report

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Dr. McKenna - Recognizing November as National Runaway and Homeless Youth Prevention Month (Res-020-24/25) (For Action November 19, 2024)

Whereas, November is National Runaway and Homeless Youth Prevention Month;

Whereas, Runaway and homeless youth, defined as young people between 12 and 24 years of age, have the least access to essential opportunities and supports;

Whereas, The prevalence of runaways and homelessness among youth is staggering, with studies suggesting that nationally between 1,600,000 and 2,800,000 youth up to 24 years of age experience homelessness every year, of which an overrepresentation, compared to the general youth population, are youth of color, gay, lesbian, bisexual, or transgender;

Whereas, Based on national surveys and California's youth population, an estimated 200,000 youth under 18 years of age, and thousands more who are 18 to 24 years of age, are homeless for one or more days each year;

Whereas, The percentage of unaccompanied homeless youth who are unsheltered in California stands at 68.2 percent, which is the second highest in the country. California also has 29 percent of the homeless youth in the country, the largest number of homeless youth of any state;

Whereas, An estimated 44,007 children and youth experienced homelessness in Los Angeles County in the 2023-2024 school year;

Whereas, Runaway and homeless youth flee conflict, abuse, neglect, or increasingly, poverty in their homes. They have become disconnected from educational systems and the workforce, and do not have the skills and financial resources to live on their own. The factors impacting youth homelessness are complex and differ from those impacting other homeless populations;

Whereas, Runaway and homeless youth who live on the street are victims of physical abuse, sexual exploitation, human trafficking, and crime in untold numbers. An estimated 300,000 youth are either victims or at risk of becoming victims of the commercial sexual exploitation of children each year, and sixty percent of these victimized children are homeless;

Whereas, Homeless youth tend to have started using drugs at a younger age, often before 15 years of age. Early drug use and abuse is predictive of serious adult addiction problems and long-term homelessness;

Whereas, Youth who "age out" of the foster care system are at an increased risk of homelessness, and represent an estimated 20 percent of the 20,000 youth who leave foster care and are currently homeless;

Whereas, Youth without a high school diploma are 346 percent more likely to experience homelessness than their peers who complete high school;

Whereas, Providing safe, stable, and permanent housing for runaway and homeless youth is a family, community, state, and national priority, and homeless youth are considered one of the unique populations in the homeless community by the United States Interagency Council on Homelessness;

Whereas, The future well-being of our state depends on the value we place on our youth, and, in particular, on our actions to provide the most vulnerable young people in the state with opportunities to acquire the knowledge, skills, and abilities they need to find and maintain stable housing and develop into healthy and productive adults;

Whereas, When targeted resources are invested, we see a significant increase in the number of communities with youth-specific housing and programs that will help prevent youth from becoming chronically homeless. California has increased the number of youth beds from 3,159 in 2015 to 6,240 in 2023;

Whereas, The California Coalition for Youth has operated the California Youth Crisis Line (1-800-843-5200), 24 hours a day, seven days a week, for over 30 years as the state's only emergency response system for youth in crisis, and which began offering chat-to-text counseling services in 2016;

Whereas, The California Coalition for Youth, along with other community-based organizations, providers, and advocates, are sponsoring California's thirteenth annual Runaway and Homeless Youth Prevention Month to increase awareness and action on behalf of youth at risk or currently living on the street;

Whereas, The Governing Board of the Los Angeles Unified School District recognizes the important role education can play in preventing and ending youth homelessness; the District provides assistance to children, youth, and families experiencing homelessness ensuring their access to the same free, appropriate public education, including public preschools, provided to other children and youth; and

Whereas, Awareness of the tragedy of youth experiencing homelessness and its causes must be heightened to ensure greater support for effective programs aimed at preventing homelessness and helping youth remain off the streets; now, therefore, be it

Resolved, That the Governing Board of the Los Angeles Unified School District declares November 2024 Homeless Youth Awareness Month; and, be it finally

Resolved, That the Los Angeles Unified School District recognizes the unique challenges of youth experiencing homelessness and commits to increasing awareness of the issues impacting these students and will continue to support and explore programs, partnerships, and legislation that combat homelessness and remove barriers to success for homeless youth.